IRISH RETAIL PULSE

Sector Performance and Consumer Trends 2021–2026

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Data Source: Central Statistics Office Ireland
April 2026

WHAT THIS REPORT IS ABOUT

This report was produced as an independent data analytics portfolio project. It uses official Irish government data to answer one practical question: which retail sectors in Ireland are genuinely growing, which are under pressure, and what should businesses do about it?

It is written for a non-technical audience. No data science background is needed to read it.

1. Executive Summary

This report analyses 62 months of Irish retail sales data published by the Central Statistics Office (CSO), covering 13 retail sectors from January 2021 to February 2026.

Three findings stand out:

- Irish retail revenue has grown by approximately 29% since 2021. However, the actual volume of goods sold has grown by only around 16%. The gap between these two numbers means most of the revenue growth is driven by higher prices, not more people buying more things.
- Three sectors — Food Specialised stores, Electrical Goods, and Food Non-Specialised — have declined in real sales volume, year after year, regardless of the wider economy. This suggests a structural shift in how Irish consumers shop, not a temporary dip.
- Sectors like Clothing & Footwear and Bars appear to have grown dramatically over the period. This is largely a COVID recovery effect — both were forced to close in early 2021, so their percentage growth reflects reopening, not exceptional business performance.

In plain English:

Irish shops are making more money, but they are not necessarily serving more customers or selling more goods. Much of the extra revenue comes from charging higher prices. That is an important distinction for any business planning for the future.

2. Data Description

All data in this report comes from the Central Statistics Office (CSO), which is the Irish government's official statistics body. The specific dataset used is called the Retail Sales Index (RSI), published monthly.

The CSO surveys hundreds of Irish retail businesses every month and produces two separate measures:

Measure	What it means
Value Index	The total amount of money spent in a retail sector. If prices rise, this number goes up even if fewer items were sold.
Volume Index	The real amount of goods sold, with price changes removed. This reflects actual consumer demand — how much people are truly buying, not just how much they are spending.

Both measures are expressed as index numbers relative to a base year of 2021 = 100. A number above 100 means a sector is performing better than it did in 2021. A number below 100 means it is performing worse.

Why does this distinction matter?

Imagine a clothing shop sold 100 jumpers in 2021 at €20 each (€2,000 revenue). In 2023 they sold 90 jumpers at €30 each (€2,700 revenue). The Value Index went up — they made more money. But the Volume Index went down — they actually sold fewer jumpers. Tracking both tells the full story.

The analysis covers 13 individual retail sectors, 62 months of monthly data, and was processed using PostgreSQL, Python, and Power BI.

3. The Interactive Dashboard

The findings from this analysis were built into a three-page interactive dashboard in Microsoft Power BI. Each page answers a different business question. The dashboard allows a user to filter by sector and by year using slicers on the right-hand side.

Page 1 — Macro Overview

This page shows the big picture: how has Irish retail performed overall since 2021? The three number cards at the top show the headline figures at a glance. The line chart below tells the inflation story visually.

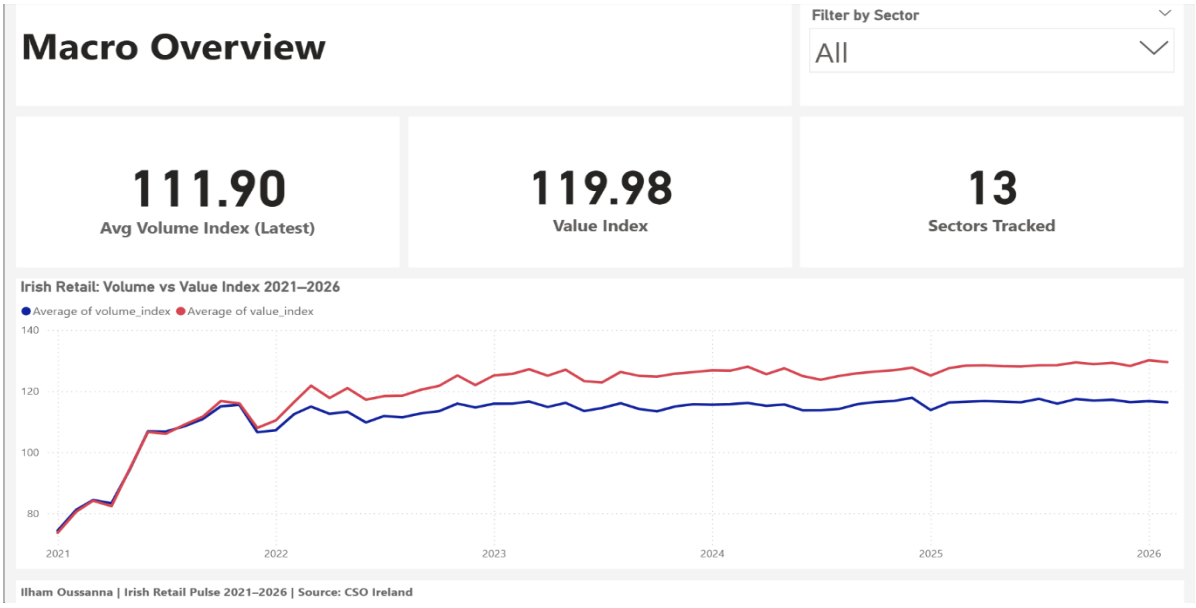


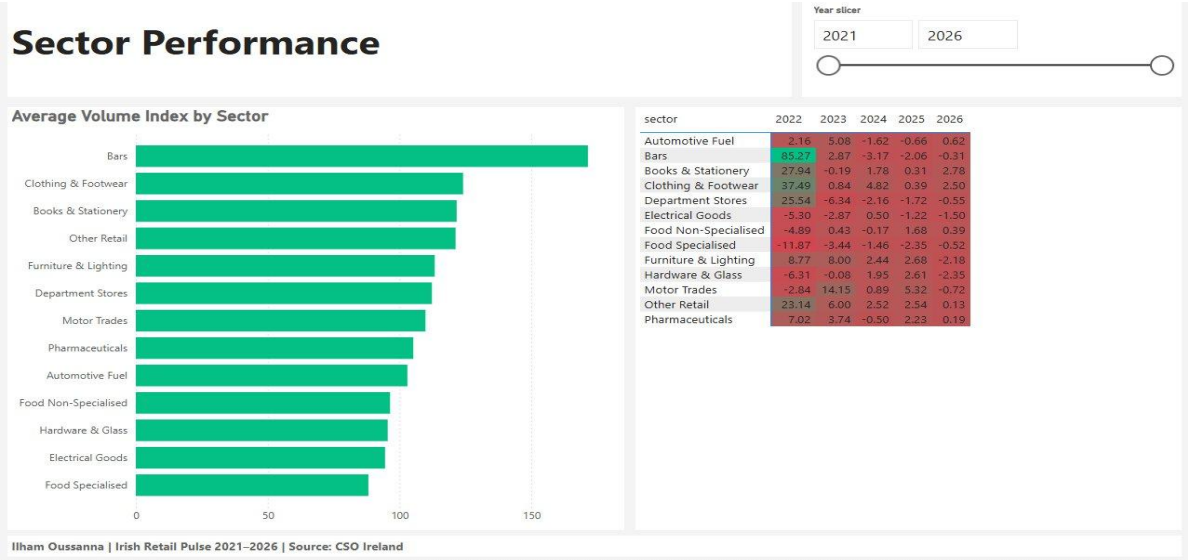
Figure 1: Macro Overview page — overall Irish retail trend 2021–2026

What the numbers mean: Volume Index of 111.90 means Irish retail is selling about 12% more in real terms than in 2021. Value Index of 119.98 means retailers are earning about 20% more revenue. The gap between those two numbers — roughly 8 points — is the inflation effect.

What the line chart shows: The blue line (volume) and red line (value) start together in early 2021. From 2022 onward they separate, with the red line climbing higher. Every month where the red line sits above the blue line, Irish consumers are paying more but not necessarily buying more.

Page 2 — Sector Performance

This page allows a user to compare all 13 retail sectors side by side. The bar chart on the left ranks sectors by their average volume index. The colour-coded grid on the right shows each sector's performance year by year — green means growth, red means decline.



sector	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Automotive Fuel	2.16	5.08	-1.62	-0.66	0.62
Bars	85.27	2.87	-3.17	-2.06	-0.31
Books & Stationery	27.94	-0.19	1.78	0.31	2.78
Clothing & Footwear	37.49	0.84	4.82	0.39	2.50
Department Stores	25.54	-6.34	-2.16	-1.72	-0.55
Electrical Goods	-5.30	-2.87	0.50	-1.22	-1.50
Food Non-Specialised	-4.89	0.43	-0.17	1.68	0.39
Food Specialised	-11.87	-3.44	-1.46	-2.35	-0.52
Furniture & Lighting	8.77	8.00	2.44	2.68	-2.18
Hardware & Glass	-6.31	-0.08	1.95	2.61	-2.35
Motor Trades	-2.84	14.15	0.89	5.32	-0.72
Other Retail	23.14	6.00	2.52	2.54	0.13
Pharmaceuticals	7.02	3.74	-0.50	2.23	0.19

Figure 2: Sector Performance page — rankings and year-by-year grid

What the bar chart shows: Bars and Clothing & Footwear appear at the top because of their COVID recovery bounce in 2022. The more meaningful story is at the bottom: Food Specialised consistently underperforms, sitting below all other sectors.

What the grid shows: Red cells indicate years where a sector declined in real volume. Food Specialised shows red in every single column from 2022 to 2026 — the only sector with consistent decline across the full period. Electrical Goods and Food Non-Specialised also show persistent red. Furniture & Lighting and Books & Stationery show mostly green — genuine sustained growth.

Interactive feature: The Year Slicer in the top right allows a user to narrow the view to any specific year or range, making it easy to compare performance before and after inflation.

Page 3 — Seasonality & Planning

This page answers a practical planning question: which months are the busiest and quietest for any given retail sector? A user selects a sector from the dropdown on the right and the bar chart updates immediately to show average sales volume for each calendar month.

Figure 3: Seasonality & Planning page — monthly volume patterns by sector

What this shows for Clothing & Footwear: The chart currently shows Clothing & Footwear. January and February are clearly the quietest months. Sales build steadily through spring and summer and peak in the autumn-to-Christmas window. A buying team, marketing planner, or operations manager can use this directly to time promotions, staff rosters, and stock orders.

Business value: Any retailer that plans their year as if every month were equal is leaving money on the table. This chart, built from five years of real Irish data, shows exactly when each category peaks and troughs.

4. Key Findings

Finding 1 — Revenue Is Up. Real Demand Is Not.

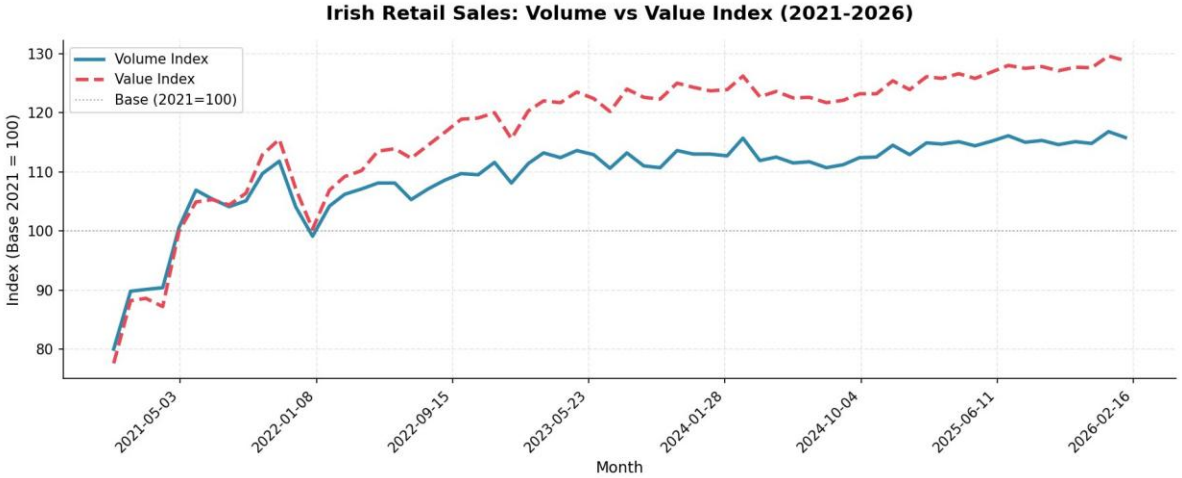


Chart 1: Overall Irish retail volume vs value index, January 2021 to February 2026

The chart above shows two lines across 62 months of Irish retail data. The blue line tracks the Volume Index — how much is actually being sold in real terms. The red dashed line tracks the Value Index — how much money consumers are spending.

In early 2021 both lines move together. From mid-2022 onward, the red line climbs faster and stays higher. By early 2026, value sits at around 129 while volume sits at around 116. That 13-point gap is the inflation premium built into Irish retail revenue.

What this means for a business:

A retailer reporting strong revenue growth should ask: is this growth because more customers are buying more things, or because we are charging more for the same things? The volume index answers that question. If volume is flat or declining while revenue is up, the business is not actually growing — it is inflating. Planning for investment, hiring, or expansion on the basis of revenue alone, without checking volume, creates a misleading picture.

Finding 2 — Which Sectors Are Winning and Losing

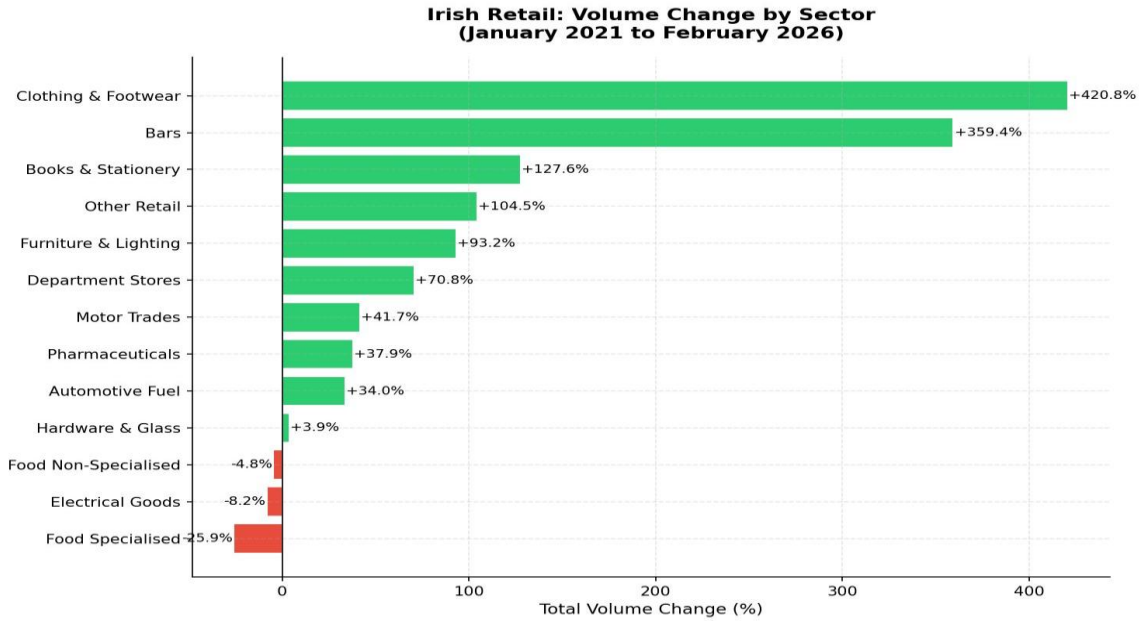


Chart 2: Total volume change by sector, January 2021 to February 2026

This chart ranks all 13 sectors by how much their real sales volume has changed from the start of the dataset to the most recent month. Green bars indicate growth. Red bars indicate decline.

> **Important context — the COVID effect:**
> Clothing & Footwear (+420.8%) and Bars (+359.4%) look extraordinary. They are not. Both sectors were operating under severe government restrictions in January 2021 — clothing shops and bars were largely closed or severely limited. Their large percentage gains reflect reopening from near-zero, not genuine business growth. Adjusted for this, both sectors have grown at modest rates since 2022.

The more meaningful story is the consistent underperformers:

- Food Specialised stores (−25.9%) — this covers specialist food shops, delicatessens, and similar. This decline has continued every year regardless of inflation or macro conditions. Irish consumers are consolidating food shopping into larger supermarkets.
- Electrical Goods (−8.2%) — declining volume likely reflects a shift to online purchasing through retailers not registered in Ireland, which fall outside the scope of the CSO survey.
- Food Non-Specialised (−4.8%) — the large supermarket category has also seen modest volume decline, suggesting consumers are managing basket sizes carefully despite the higher prices they are paying.

Hardware & Glass (+3.9%), Motor Trades (+41.7%), and Pharmaceuticals (+37.9%) show genuine growth that cannot be attributed to COVID base effects.

Finding 3 — Where Prices Rose Faster Than Demand

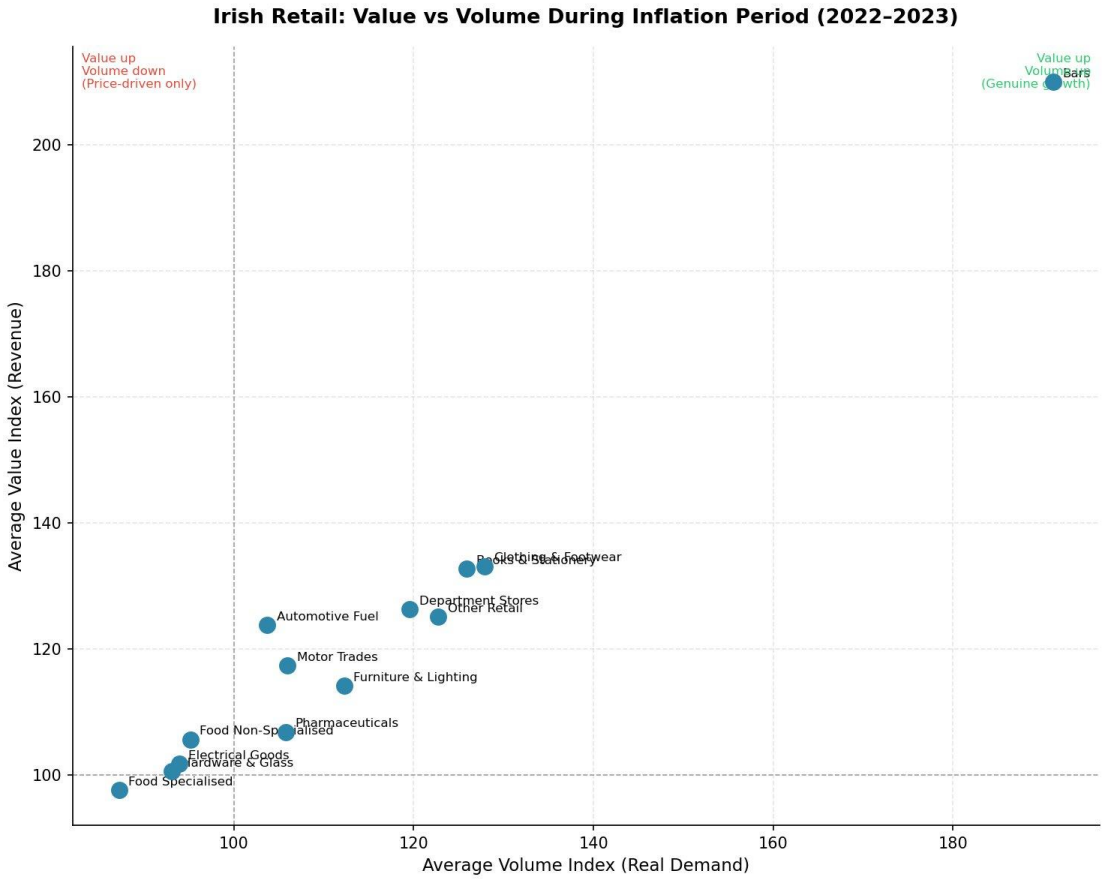


Chart 3: Value vs Volume during the inflation period 2022–2023. Each dot is one sector.

This chart places each retail sector as a dot based on two things: how much its revenue grew during 2022–2023 (upward on the chart) and how much its real demand grew during the same period (rightward on the chart). The two dashed lines crossing in the middle mark the 2021 base level of 100.

Almost every sector sits to the left of the vertical line at 100 — meaning real demand was below 2021 levels during the inflation peak. Yet almost every sector also sits above the horizontal line at 100 — meaning revenue was above 2021 levels. Retailers were charging more and selling less.

Food Specialised is the extreme case in the bottom left: revenue barely held above 100 while volume collapsed well below it. Bars is the outlier in the top right — but again, this reflects COVID reopening in 2022, not genuine demand surge.

What this means:

For most of 2022 and 2023, Irish consumers were being squeezed by rising prices across almost every retail category. They spent more money but bought fewer goods. A brand or supplier monitoring only revenue would have seen healthy-looking numbers while the underlying demand picture told a different story entirely.

Finding 4 — Year-by-Year Sector Breakdown

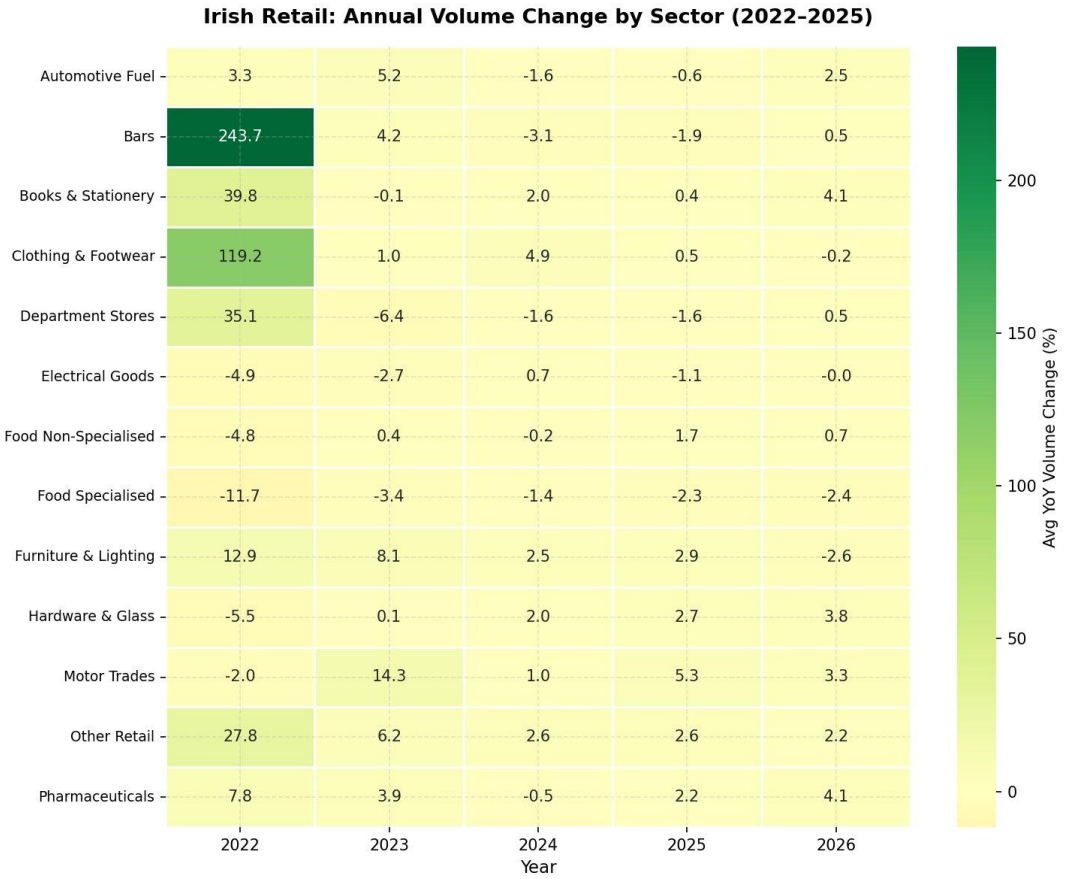


Chart 4: Average year-on-year volume change by sector, 2022–2026. Green = growth, red = decline.

This grid shows each sector's average year-on-year volume change for each calendar year. It makes patterns visible at a glance that would be invisible in a table of numbers.

Three patterns stand out immediately:

- The 2022 column is dominated by green — the post-COVID reopening recovery pushed almost every sector upward that year, especially Bars (243.7%) and Clothing (119.2%).
- From 2023 onward, the grid turns pale and mixed. The recovery momentum ran out. Most sectors settled into low single-digit growth or slight declines across 2023, 2024, and 2025.
- Food Specialised is the only sector that shows red in every single year, including 2022. It did not benefit from the reopening bounce and has declined continuously throughout the period.

Hardware & Glass is the quiet positive story — consistent growth building from 0.1% in 2023 to 2.0% in 2024 to 2.7% in 2025 and 3.8% in 2026. Steady, not dramatic, but reliable.

Finding 5 — Seasonal Patterns

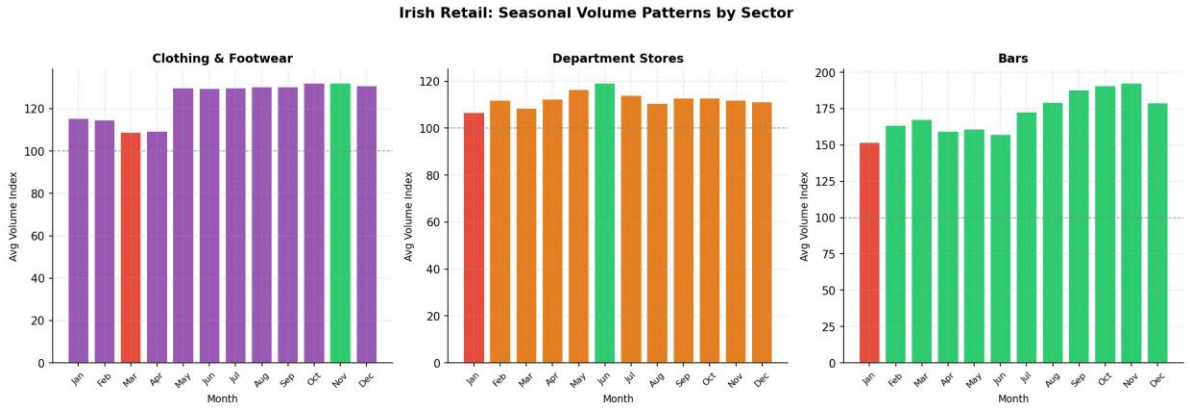


Chart 5: Average monthly volume patterns for Clothing & Footwear, Department Stores, and Bars

These three charts show the average sales volume for each calendar month, built from five years of data. The patterns are consistent and predictable enough to be used directly in business planning.

- Clothing & Footwear peaks in December (Christmas) and troughs in March. The swing is about 20 index points — a difference of roughly 20% between the best and worst months.
- Department Stores show surprisingly flat seasonality, with only a modest June peak. They do not have a strong seasonal spike to capitalise on, unlike most other retail categories.
- Bars show the most dramatic seasonal pattern. January is by far the lowest month — significantly below every other month. October and November are the peaks. The gap between peak and trough is the largest of any sector analysed.

What this means for planning:

A clothing retailer concentrating marketing budget and stock in Q4 is backed by five years of Irish data. A bar owner treating January as a genuinely quiet month that requires cost management — not just a quiet week — is also backed by the data. Planning assumptions should come from evidence, not gut feel.

5. Recommendations

Based on the five findings above, three actions stand out for Irish retail businesses and the analysts who support them.

Recommendation 1 — Track volume alongside revenue in all internal reporting

Any business that measures success using revenue alone is working with an incomplete picture. Revenue can rise even when real demand is falling, if prices are going up. Adding a volume measure to every performance dashboard or monthly report would immediately reveal whether growth is genuine or inflation driven.

This is a straightforward change to implement. Most businesses already collect the data needed. The gap is in how it is presented and what questions are asked of it.

Recommendation 2 — Review strategy for consistently declining sectors

Food Specialised, Electrical Goods, and Food Non-Specialised have declined in real volume every year in this dataset. For a brand, supplier, or retailer with significant exposure to any of these channels, the data is a prompt to ask hard questions about channel strategy, physical footprint, and where investment is being directed.

A five-year consistent decline in a category does not reverse on its own. It requires either a deliberate strategic response or a decision to redirect resources elsewhere.

Recommendation 3 — Build seasonal planning calendars from data, not assumption

The monthly patterns in this report are derived from 62 months of actual Irish retail data. They are more reliable than assumptions based on a single year's experience or anecdotal trading patterns. Any team responsible for buying, marketing, staffing, or operations in a seasonal retail category should be using data like this to set their annual calendar.

The practical output would be a simple monthly index for each relevant category, updated annually as new CSO data is published, used to weight budget allocation, staffing levels, and promotional timing across the year.

6. Methodology and Tools

This section provides a brief overview of how the analysis was conducted, for readers who want to understand the technical process.

Data Source

Central Statistics Office Ireland — Retail Sales Index, Table RSM08. Downloaded April 2026. The dataset contained 10,912 rows covering 8 statistical measures, 22 NACE sector groupings, and 62 monthly periods from January 2021 to February 2026.

Data Preparation

The raw dataset was loaded into a PostgreSQL database for verification. Row counts, distinct sector names, and date ranges were confirmed before any analysis began. The data was then cleaned and reshaped using Python (Pandas library): 6 of the 8 statistical measures were removed as unnecessary for this analysis, leaving only the seasonally adjusted Value Index and Volume Index. Overlapping sector groupings were removed, leaving 13 individual sectors plus one all-businesses aggregate. The month column was converted from text format to proper dates. The final clean dataset contained 868 rows.

Analysis

All charts were produced in Python using the Matplotlib and Seaborn libraries in a Jupyter notebook. Year-on-year percentage changes were calculated directly from the index values. The inflation period analysis used monthly averages across 2022 and 2023. Seasonal patterns were calculated as the average volume index for each calendar month across all available years.

Dashboard

The interactive dashboard was built in Microsoft Power BI Desktop using the cleaned dataset. Three report pages were created covering the macro-overview, sector performance, and seasonality analysis. Conditional formatting was applied to the sector matrix to highlight growth and decline visually.

This report was produced as part of an independent data analytics portfolio project by Ilham Oussanna. It does not represent the views of the CSO or any commercial organisation. Data is used under the CSO open data licence.